

TransUnion may ask for verification of loan numbers and credit card account numbers, so be a good scout and be prepared. They may also want you to confirm employment information during a certain timeframe. Experian and Equifax may ask questions about your personal financial information, so you need to know who you have your mortgage with and what county you live in.

After you have answered the questions satisfactorily, your credit report pops up. Print it. Read it. There can be a lot of pages. We'll get to the nitty gritty on this in a moment.

Some sites may ask if you want to pay to get your FICO score. (We'll talk more about FICO scores in a second.) It usually is a good idea to get your FICO score.

What You Do Now

If you are like most people, what you want to do now is take a break. What you should do is look yourself in the eye and feel good about the knowledge you are acquiring. You are well on your way to getting out of the financial hole, and if you stick with me long enough, you will soon ascend to the financial mountaintop. Trust me, you will never regret it.

Okay, you have your credit reports in hand. Now you need to take the time to review all the information reported there. I know how tempting it can be to set paperwork aside, with very good intentions to get to it after more "pressing matters" like dinner, the laundry, or hmm...paying bills. Nothing is more pressing than making sure your credit report is up-to-date and accurate. That is the information that is used to determine your credit score, and the credit score is what is used to determine your interest rates on all your loans and credit cards. All your bills and financial bottom line depend on it!

Read the Lines

Take the time to read it through. Most items are obvious; a few need explanation.

- ✓ The creditor's name
- ✓ The creditor's address